

## Mary Kay: A Leader in the Beauty Product Industry

Mary Kay Cosmetics is an international company that sells beauty products.

One woman started the business in the 1960s with an investment of \$5,000.

Mary Kathlyn Wagner was born in the state of Texas in 1918. For much of her childhood, she cared for her sick father while her mother worked long hours at a restaurant.

Mary Kay married Ben Rogers when she was 17 years old. They had three children before he left home to serve in World War Two. When he returned, their marriage ended. Mary Kay looked for a job so she could support her children.

She began selling different kinds of products. One night, Mary Kay was showing products at the home of Ova Heath Spoonemore. Ms. Spoonemore began giving her guests some homemade skin care products. The products were developed by her father, J.W. Heath, in Arkansas. Mary Kay tried the skin care products and liked them.

Mary Kay Ash, president of Mary Kay Cosmetics, is seen in her Dallas, Tex., office, Jan. 1982. (AP Photo)

She bought the rights to Heath's skin care products and started her own company. She paid \$500 for the legal rights to the products. And in 1963, The Mary Kay Cosmetics company began operating in Dallas, Texas.

The idea was to sell skin care products through demonstrations in homes and offices. Independent sales representatives bought beauty products from the company and sold them at higher prices.

Mary Kay decided that each representative who brought other saleswomen into the company would receive part of the new person's earnings. That way, experienced sales representatives would be willing to train new ones.

By 1965, the company was selling almost one million dollars in products.

Mary Kay Cosmetics became one of the most successful direct sellers of skin care products in America. It continues to have sales offices and representatives in many different countries.

Mary Kay Global Headquarters building in Addison, Texas (Photo: Business Wire via AP)

Mary Kay aimed to grow sales based on the idea that it is best to compete against yourself. That means every individual is trying to beat their own sales records. Prizes for high sales marks included special paid holidays and jewelry. Until a few years ago, a pink Cadillac was a top prize.

Students celebrate International Day of Women and Girls in Science at Mary Kay research center, Feb. 11, 2025. (Photo: Mary Kay Inc. via AP)

After her third husband, Mel Ash, died of cancer in 1980, she wanted to help find a cure for the disease. At first, she helped organizations raise money for research.

Later, she started the Mary Kay Ash Charitable Foundation, a nonprofit group that provides money to support research on cancers affecting women. In 2001, the company and foundation expanded their goals to help prevent violence against women.

Students from Lewisville High School – Harmon Campus (Texas, U.S.A.) putting their knowledge to the test by creating their own Mary Kay® Unlimited Lip Gloss at Mary Kay's global Richard R. Rogers Manufacturing and Research & Development Center (Photo Credit: Mary Kay Inc. via AP)

Female entrepreneurs in Chuxiong, Yunnan Province increased their income and helped preserve the Yunnan Embroidery cultural industry thanks to Mary Kay Women's Entrepreneurship Program, Jan. 30, 2014. (Photo: Mary Kay Inc. via AP)

Mary Kay Ash also wrote three books. She worked in her business until she suffered a stroke in 1996. She died in 2001.

Sales representatives say Mary Kay developed a way for women to earn money and still spend time with their families.

I'm Anna Matteo.

Nancy Steinbach wrote this story for VOA Special English. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

## Vocabulary

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stroke - n. อาการเส้นเลือดในสมองแตกหรือตีบ (ภาวะที่เลือดไปเลี้ยงสมองไม่พอ)

## Reading Comprehension Quiz

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**1. What kind of products does Mary Kay Cosmetics primarily sell?**

- Home furnishings
- Beauty products
- Food items
- Automotive parts

**2. What was the initial investment made to start the Mary Kay Cosmetics business?**

\$1,960

\$5,000  
\$10,000  
\$17,000

**3. What was Mary Kathlyn Wagner's main responsibility during much of her early life?**

Working at a restaurant  
Attending school  
Caring for her sick father  
Traveling with her family

**4. Why did Mary Kay look for a job after her husband returned from World War Two?**

She wanted to pursue a career in beauty.  
Her husband encouraged her to work.  
Their marriage ended, and she needed to support her children.  
She was bored at home and wanted new challenges.

**5. Where did Mary Kay first encounter the homemade skin care products that impressed her?**

At a department store  
At her own home  
At the home of Ova Heath Spoonemore  
At a beauty convention

**6. Who was responsible for developing the skin care products that Mary Kay later acquired?**

Ova Heath Spoonemore  
J.W. Heath  
Ben Rogers  
Mary Kathlyn Wagner herself

**7. How much did Mary Kay pay to secure the legal rights to J.W. Heath's skin care products?**

\$50  
\$100  
\$500  
\$1,000

**8. In what specific year and city did Mary Kay Cosmetics officially begin its operations?**

1960 in Houston, Texas

1963 in Dallas, Texas

1965 in New York City, New York

1982 in Addison, Texas

**9. What was the primary sales strategy for Mary Kay Cosmetics in its early days?**

Selling directly through large retail stores

Online sales platforms

Demonstrations in homes and offices

Telemarketing campaigns

**10. What incentive did Mary Kay offer to encourage existing sales representatives to bring in new saleswomen?**

A fixed bonus for each new hire

Part of the new person's earnings

A promotion to a managerial role

Exclusive access to new products

**11. By 1965, approximately how much in products was Mary Kay Cosmetics selling?**

Exactly one million dollars

Less than five hundred thousand dollars

Almost one million dollars

Over two million dollars

**12. What was Mary Kay Cosmetics recognized as in America?**

The largest manufacturer of beauty products

One of the most successful direct sellers of skin care products

A leader in online beauty sales

The oldest beauty company in Texas

**13. According to the article, what was Mary Kay's philosophy for growing sales?**

To outperform competitors aggressively

To focus on international market expansion

To encourage individuals to beat their own sales records

To constantly innovate with new product lines

**14. What personal tragedy prompted Mary Kay Ash to become involved in fundraising for cancer research?**

Her mother was diagnosed with cancer.

Her third husband, Mel Ash, died of cancer.

She herself battled with cancer.

A close friend passed away from the disease.

**15. In addition to supporting cancer research, what other major goal did the Mary Kay Ash Charitable Foundation adopt in 2001?**

Providing scholarships for women in business

Funding animal welfare initiatives

Helping to prevent violence against women

Promoting environmental conservation